

AI data centers are using as much power as 100,000 homes and you're subsidizing it through your electric bill

Posted by u/reddit20305 • • 0 points • 48 comments

NPR just published something yesterday that connects all the dots on why your power bill keeps increasing.

One typical AI data center uses as much electricity as 100,000 homes. The largest data centers under development will use 20 times more than that.

And you're paying for it.

Here's how you're paying for it. Power companies had to build new transmission lines to reach data centers. Cost to build those lines? \$4.3 billion in 2024 just in seven states. Illinois, Maryland, New Jersey, Ohio, Pennsylvania, Virginia and West Virginia.

Who pays for building those transmission lines? You do. Through higher electricity rates. It's not a separate charge. Your overall rate goes up to cover the infrastructure costs. Millions of people splitting \$4.3 billion in extra costs they never agreed to.

The data center industry says they pay their share. But the Union of Concerned Scientists found regular homes and businesses are covering billions in infrastructure costs to deliver power to data centers that only benefit tech companies.

Google tried to build a data center complex in Franklin Indiana. Needed to rezone 450 acres. Residents found out how much water and power it would consume. Public meeting happened in September. Google's lawyer confirmed they were pulling out. Crowd erupted in cheers.

Similar fights happening all over the US. Tech companies pouring billions into data centers for AI. Residents pushing back because of environmental impact power prices and what it does to their communities.

Data centers have been around for decades but there's an AI investment frenzy right now driving a construction boom. Within two years of ChatGPT launching 40% of households in US and UK were using AI chatbots. Companies saw that and started building massive

infrastructure.

Tech companies are spending hundreds of billions on data centers and AI chips betting more people will use the technology. By 2027 AI is expected to account for 28% of the global data center market. Up from 14% now.

The construction is spreading everywhere. Northern Virginia's Data Center Alley. Parts of Texas. Las Vegas. Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis said a potential data center boom is just getting started in their district covering Minnesota Montana North Dakota South Dakota and parts of Michigan and Wisconsin.

But here's what nobody talks about until it's too late. These facilities don't just use electricity. They suck up billions of gallons of water for cooling systems.

In Georgia residents reported problems getting drinking water from their wells after a data center was built nearby. The data center was using so much water it affected the local supply.

Arizona cities started restricting water deliveries to facilities that use a lot of water including data centers. The Great Lakes region is seeing a flurry of data center activity and researchers are asking how much more water the lakes can provide.

Some data centers use evaporative cooling where water is lost as steam. Others use closed loop systems that consume less water. There's a push for waterless cooling but that uses way more electricity instead.

It's a trade off. Use more electricity to cool and less water. Or use more water and less electricity. Either way the cost gets passed to you.

The industry says they're working on it. Google has a data center in Georgia that uses treated wastewater and returns it to the river. Some companies are exploring different cooling technologies.

But the construction is happening faster than the solutions. Data centers are being built right now with cooling systems that need massive amounts of water and power. The efficiency improvements come later maybe.

And once they're built data centers don't create many permanent jobs. Takes a lot of people to construct them but only a small team to operate them. So communities get the environmental impact and higher utility bills but not the long term employment.

Some localities are offering tax breaks to attract data center projects. Giving up tax revenue

in exchange for construction jobs that disappear once the facility is done.

The bigger problem is electricity supply. Power demand in the US is spiking. Data centers are a major driver but also factories electric vehicles home appliances. Everything's going electric at the same time.

Trump administration has been limiting development of renewable energy projects. But industry executives say renewables are crucial because they can be built quickly and generate relatively cheap electricity.

White House says AI can't rely on "unreliable sources of energy that must be heavily subsidized." They want natural gas and nuclear. But energy analysts agree those can't be deployed fast enough to meet immediate demand.

Solar and wind with battery storage are reliable now. There's broad agreement that natural gas and nuclear will play a role. But the timeline doesn't work if you only focus on those.

Meanwhile data centers keep getting built. Power demand keeps rising. Your bill keeps going up.

The frustration isn't just about cost. Tech companies aren't transparent about their operations. Without data on water and energy consumption people can't make informed decisions about whether they want these facilities in their communities.

Industry says sharing that information could give competitors an edge. So they stay quiet. Build the data centers. Let people find out about the impact after it's too late.

This is what's funding the AI boom. Not just the billions tech companies are spending. It's billions more in infrastructure costs getting passed to regular people through utility bills.

You're subsidizing the AI infrastructure whether you use AI or not. Whether you want data centers in your area or not. The costs are distributed across entire regions.

By 2027 AI data centers could need 68 gigawatts of power capacity. That's close to the total power capacity of California right now. And climate pollution from power plants running data centers could more than double by 2035.

All so companies can compete in AI. So they can process ChatGPT queries. So they can train models that might or might not transform how people work.

And you're paying for it through your electric bill.

TLDR: AI data center uses electricity of 100,000 households. Largest ones use 20x more. Homes in 7 states paid extra \$4.3 billion in 2024 for transmission lines to data centers. Google pulled out of Indiana after residents revolted. Data centers suck billions of gallons of water. Georgia residents lost well water after data center moved in. Your bills are going up to subsidize AI infrastructure.

****Sources:****

NPR investigation: <https://www.npr.org/2025/10/14/nx-s1-5565147/google-ai-data-centers-growth-environment-electricity>

Union of Concerned Scientists analysis: <https://blog.ucs.org/mike-jacobs/data-centers-are-already-increasing-your-energy-bills/>

International Energy Agency report: [<https://iea.blob.core.windows.net/assets/601eaec9-ba91-4623-819b-4ded331ec9e8/EnergyandAI.pdf>]
(<https://iea.blob.core.windows.net/assets/601eaec9-ba91-4623-819b-4ded331ec9e8/EnergyandAI.pdf>)

RAND study on power demand: [https://www.rand.org/pubs/research_reports/RRA3572-1.html](https://www.rand.org/pubs/research_reports/RRA3572-1.html)

Comments

u/Next-Illustrator7493 • 1 points • 2026-04-06 14:00 UTC

How many new pharmaceuticals were created with cloud computing?

If you care so much about electricity. Don't run your A/C this year. Wear a fucking blanket in March and don't turn your furnace on. I'm more than happy to give my electricity to a machine that is literally curing cancer.

u/PanicIntelligent1204 • 1 points • 2025-10-19 11:09 UTC

Yikes, that's crazy!

also working on something worth sharing? post it to [justgotfound](<https://justgotfound.com>)

u/Shap3rz • 1 points • 2025-10-18 18:42 UTC

And hyperscaler AI is just for sex bots and better spying. It's so evil. Manufacturing dependency, whilst getting regular people to pay for it, and taking their water and accelerating climate change. It's a crime imo. These people need to be held to account. But they are beyond reproach. Sad times indeed.

u/BloomCountyBlue • 1 points • 2025-10-15 23:22 UTC

Except for listing some US states in the 4th paragraph, not a single comma was used in that whole post. Just an observation.

u/CodFull2902 • 1 points • 2025-10-15 22:57 UTC

Well, whats the alternative? Entirely concede AI and therefore control of the entire world economy to the Chinese?

u/FewResident3990 • 4 points • 2025-10-15 22:24 UTC

People making this argument have no idea how much their own individual lives are dependent on these data centers. As if you wouldn't miss it if it was gone and nobody paid for it. If you want, go off grid and stop using the internet. Or build your own server farm and pay for the power to it on your own. Otherwise, it's not a good argument.

u/bassrooster • 1 points • 2025-10-15 22:08 UTC

My local power company has "flex events" where they challenge me to reduce electricity usage. They told me it was to keep enough electricity and avoid brownouts.

Do the AI centers power down during these events or are they exempt?

u/Difficult-Regular-37 • 1 points • 2025-10-15 20:41 UTC

would you tell an artist to stop painting because there are no more trees left for their paper?

power/water is the invisible backbone of any economy which relies on innovation, computing, AI research.

why do these governments around the world still treat the foundations of first-world economies as an afterthought?

a trillion dollar opportunity needs a trillion dollar investment.

so the problem is not with AI itself, its with the long-term strategy of infrastructure development in USA/UK/EU.

they forget what made their economies stable in the first place.

u/Bernie4Life420 • 1 points • 2025-10-15 16:33 UTC

At least we're using it to cure disease and push the cutting edges of technology and research!

u/Terrariant • 2 points • 2025-10-15 15:27 UTC

!giphy(11FiDF2fuOujPG)